> on politics. I found him intelligent and well informed on the subject of Northern Asia. He very frankly said it was not the custom of Russia to publish to the world the result of its researches in foreign countries, as was the case in France or England.

Burnes then added: ‘I never again saw Mr Vitkevitch, although we exchanged sundry messages of “high consideration”, for I regret to say I found it impossible to follow the dictates of my personal feelings of friendship towards him, as the public service required the strictest watch.’[89] This was no understatement: Burnes had already begun to intercept his dining companion’s letters back to Teheran and St Petersburg, and vice versa.

In the weeks that followed, Burnes put a brave face on his increasingly uncomfortable situation. He was well aware how close he was to having his mission unravel, especially as there was still no sign that Lord Auckland had grasped the seriousness of what was happening in Kabul, or that he had taken in how close he was to losing both Persia and Afghanistan to the Russians. As it was, Burnes was having difficulty in keeping up with the presents that Vitkevitch was showering on the Amir: ‘Captain Vitkevitch informs the Ameer that the value of the rarities sent to him by the Emperor amounts to 60,000 Rs,’ he wrote on 18 February 1838. ‘The opposing faction have not failed to contrast this with the few trifles which I have presented to him, and to adduce it as a proof of the indifference of a nation famed, and above all in Afghanistan, for its liberality . . . Under all these circumstances it may be naturally expected how anxiously I look for the commands of Government to guide me.’[90]

But with letters taking three to four weeks to reach India, and Calcutta failing to reply to his missives, and with the news from Herat becoming ever grimmer, Burnes decided to seize the initiative. That same month he promised Rs 300,000 to the Kandahar Barakzais to help them defend themselves against the Persians if Herat fell and the Shah’s army marched into Afghanistan.

He also decided to breach protocol and, bypassing Wade and Macnaghten, wrote an impassioned letter directly to Lord Auckland pleading with him to understand what was at stake and telling him clearly that a deal was still easily within his grasp, one which without effort or expense could achieve all British aims, and which at one stroke would head off the designs of Russia and Persia. He blamed the Sikhs for their aggression in taking Peshawar and building the fort at Jamrud, and reiterated how much Dost